Dunkirk. The release of Dutch fire ships into the crowded waters spread panic. The Portuguese ship *Santa Teresa*, the largest vessel in the battle, was set ablaze and destroyed with heavy loss of life. Only a dozen ships, including *Santiago*, reached Dunkirk and safety.

The battle of the Downs was a landmark in the precipitous decline of Spanish power. In 1648 Spain was obliged to acknowledge Dutch independence after an 80-year conflict. The battle also triggered an uprising against Spanish rule in Portugal. England, meanwhile, had been humiliated by its failure to react to a violation of its coastal waters. The desire to avenge this insult contributed to the outbreak of the first Anglo-Dutch War in 1652.



1598–1653

MAARTEN TROMP

DUTCH ADMIRAL

Dutch admiral Maarten Tromp was born into a seagoing family in Briel. Twice in his early years he was captured by pirates— the first time at the age of 12— but on both occasions he regained his freedom. He proved his worth as a naval officer serving under Piet Heyn in the 1620s, and was appointed lieutenant admiral commanding the Dutch fleet in 1637. His victory at the Downs in 1639 made him a Dutch national hero. He was, however, too independent-minded to suit the States-General, which dismissed him from office in the summer of 1652. By the end of the year he was reinstated, only to be killed on August 10 at the battle of Scheveningen.

> "TOO GREAT FOR SEA ALONE, HE HAS CARVED HIMSELF AN IMAGE IN THE HEARTS OF ALL MORE LASTING THAN GRAVE'S SPLENDOR AND ITS MARBLE STONE."
>
> **JOOST VAN DEN VONDEL**, DUTCH POET, ON ADMIRAL TROMP



DUTCH-PORTUGUESE WAR

PERNAMBUCO



Date January 12-15, 1640
Forces Dutch: 41 ships; Portuguese and Spanish: c.90 ships
Losses Dutch: 3 ships; Portuguese and Spanish: c.11 ships
Location Off coast of northeast Brazil

A large Spanish-Portuguese fleet commanded by Admiral Fernão de Mascarenhas tried to retake Pernambuco, Brazil, which the Dutch had seized from Portugal. A smaller Dutch fleet under Admiral Loos gave battle near the island of Itamaraca. Loos was killed during the first day's fighting, but the Dutch continued the battle under James Huyghens. On the fourth day of the action a number of Portuguese ships were driven aground on coastal shoals. The Spanish-Portuguese force limped home. The Dutch held Pernambuco until 1654.

EIGHTY YEARS WAR

PUERTO DE CAVITE



Date June 1647
Forces Dutch: 12 ships; Spanish: coastal batteries
Losses Dutch: 1 ship; Spanish: 1 fort destroyed
Location Manila Bay, Philippines

Manila was the eastern end of the Spanish cross-Pacific trade route plied by galleons carrying silver from Acapulco in Mexico. For the Dutch this was a tempting target. On June 10, 1647, a fleet of 12 Dutch ships sailed into Manila Bay and laid siege to Puerto de Cavite. The Spanish defended the port vigorously with shore guns and sank the Dutch flagship. Although the Dutch destroyed a fort at Porta Vaga, they could not take Cavite.

WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

CULVERIN

The culverin was a long-barreled cannon typically firing a solid round shot of 17–18 pounds weight. A muzzle-loader, it was the longest-range gun on a 16th–17th century warship. Demi-culverins, firing roughly half the weight of shot, were also common. Culverins and demi-culverins were much favored by the Dutch and English, whereas the Spanish tended to prefer heavier guns with shorter range. A long-barreled gun posed problems for loading in a confined space, but the small truck carriage made the culverin relatively easy to handle. The stepped side of the carriage provided a fulcrum for the lever used to raise and lower the barrel.



English culverin
This 18-pounder culverin, dating from the English Civil War, has a caliber of 5.2 in (13.2 cm) and a range of some 3,280 yds (3,000 m).